

very careful about giving your receivers some context. This section will give specific strategies for doing so.

Useful Subject Lines

A subject line that pertains clearly to the e-mail body will help people mentally shift to the proper context before they read your message. The subject line should be brief (as many mailers will truncate long subject lines), does not need to be a complete sentence, and should give a clue to the contents of the message. For example:

Subject: need projector by Tues

John - I need the projector for Thursday's demo in New York. They need to be packed and shipped by Tuesday night.

Here the subject line summarizes nicely the most important details of the message.

If your message is in response to another piece of e-mail, your e-mail software will probably preface the subject line with Re: or RE: (for REgarding). If your e-mail composition software doesn't do this, it would be polite to put in RE: by hand.

Subject: Re: need projector by Tues

Bill - I've got the projector already packed from last week's demo, but I don't have the pointer device right now. Can you cope without it till you get back?

Information, Please

Make sure not to get too terse with your subject lines in e-mail. Typing subject lines like "Information", "Help Please", "Urgent", etc. are not helpful to the recipient of your e-mail and can be quite annoying.

Quoting Documents

If you are referring to previous e-mail, you should explicitly quote